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RAG / CONTEXT ENGINEERING

RAG IS A CONTEXT CONTRACT

The quality of a generated answer starts before the model sees the prompt.

THESIS / ONE SENTENCE

Debug the context boundary before blaming the model.

SOURCE-GROUNDED NOTE

SWIPE FOR THE SYSTEM

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THE HIDDEN QUESTION

What context did the model actually receive?

QUESTION

A vector search returned ten chunks. Is the answer now grounded?

REPLY

Not necessarily. Retrieval is only one step in the context boundary.

FOLLOW-UP

What was filtered, reranked, truncated, or omitted?

TAKEAWAY

If you cannot inspect the context, you cannot debug the answer.

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EVALUATE THE PIPELINE

Break the context contract into checks.

CHECK	QUESTION	FAILURE SIGNAL	NEXT TEST
RELEVANCE	Did we retrieve the right evidence?	Unrelated chunks	Inspect top-k
SUFFICIENCY	Is the answerable context present?	Missing facts	Test recall
NOISE	Did extra text crowd out signal?	Context overload	Compare trimmed/full
FAITHFULNESS	Does the answer stay within sources?	Unsupported claims	Verify citations

This decomposition is an editorial model for the sample, not a universal RAG architecture.

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CONTEXT CONTRACT

Before embeddings, define the boundary.

01

RETRIEVE

What source material is eligible?

02

FILTER

What rules remove irrelevant or unsafe context?

03

ASSEMBLE

What order, budget, and metadata reach the prompt?

04

VERIFY

What evidence supports the final answer?

FOUR BOXES / KEEP EACH ONE SCANNABLE

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TAKEAWAY

Debug the context before blaming the model.

RAG quality is partly a context-selection problem. Make the boundary visible.

SOURCE / LIMITATION / DISCUSSION

Lewis et al. (2020) describe combining parametric and non-parametric memory for knowledge-intensive tasks. This carousel's pipeline checks are editorial analysis.

SAVE THIS / AUDIT YOUR CONTEXT / DISCUSS BELOW